oppressed there by her family," she says. "It's a story about an alien meeting humans and finding out that we can be really tricky and complicated creatures."

The seven tracks on the album chart out this journey of "self-discovery through space exploration" in vivid technicolour. Bright synths soar over gently washed-out percussion, pensive strings float in counterpoint to blues-rock guitar licks. It also features stellar guest appearances from guitarist Warren Mendonsa (a.k.a. Blackstratblues), pianist Sahil Vasudeva, indie rock act Easy Wanderlings and others. The lyrics veer between self-love and self-criticism as Marwah speaks to friends and ex-lovers in a breathy croon.

"I'm very similar to Kiane in that I write a lot about my family, I have a lot of familial issues that I sing about," says Marwah. "Many people have reached out to me to say that they've been able to deal with their family issues while listening to me deal with mine. I think music can be really therapeutic for the person writing it and the person listening to it, and that's a very beautiful and positive experience for everyone."

Complementing the album are a 30-page comic book detailing Kiane's adventure—which launched at The Comic Book Store in Mumbai on October 8—and virtually-produced music videos that combine elements of live action, animation and video game design. Marwah and a team of over a hundred collaborators took six years to bring the project to life. "It just kept escalating and snowballing into a project of this huge scale," she says. "I kept meeting people who were on a similar wavelength and everyone was interested in collaborating. It was a lot of fun and we have a really beautiful final product to share with everyone now."

Marwah is now gearing up to take the project on the road, with concert dates lined up from November all the way to next March. She's also hoping to lock in an American tour in March 2024, alongside scoring for OTT films and television. Her next project is going to be a Hindi album, she says, but she hopes to return to the world of The Fall sometime in the future, picking up Kiane's story where she's left off. "Maybe we'll do an EP where we talk about what happens next," she says, signing off. "The next chapter of her story." ■

Bhanuj Kappal



The seven tracks on the album chart out a journey of "self-discovery through space exploration" in vivid technicolour

as a space that would energise all of us," says Angarika Guha, a researcher and practitioner at Maraa, whose work focuses on the intersections between caste, gender and labour. "That's why the idea of lightning, particularly lightning as cracking something open so you can see what's beneath."

To engage with this theme, Maraa has invited a range of artists, including the all-Dalit comedy collective Blue Material, Dakhni hip-hop crew Bokka Phod (led by rapper Pasha Bhai), the Queer Poetry Collective and Delhi rapper Kinari. As always, Maraa maintains a light curatorial touch, letting the artists explore the theme in their own way. "It's a space where people can express themselves freely, which is becoming increasingly difficult in the current socio-political reality," says Guha.

The festival kicked off with a screening of the 1992 Gujarati political satire *Hun Hunshi Hunshilal* on October 1, and events will run throughout the month. On October 21, the Bengaluru-based Nepali folk-rock band Gauley Bhai will perform a special set in collaboration with the Teesta Troupers, a collective of musicians, rappers and songwriters from Kalimpong. For the past year, the musicians in Gauley Bhai have been working with musically inclined kids from marginalised groups in the Kalimpong region, helping them refine their songs for an upcoming album. "Their lyrics reflect what's going on around them, and it felt like it was a narrative coming from the margins," says Gauley Bhai frontman Veecheet Dhakal, who has funded the project through a grant from the India Foundation for the Arts. "I thought it was really fresh and grounded."

The final event will be a concert in tribute to Telangana revolutionary poet Gaddar, who passed away earlier this year. An inter-generational lineup of artists from Karnataka, Maharashtra, Telangana and Chhattisgarh—including Gaddar contemporaries Sambhaji Bhagat and Kaladas Deheriya and next-gen admirers like lokshahiri troupe Yalgaar—will perform songs and share stories of one of India's most influential protest artists.

"Gaddar's passing was a huge loss to India's cultural movements," says Dhammaraxit Randive of Yalgaar. "He set an example for all artists who are making art of resistance.... We're looking forward to performing some of Gaddar's songs that we found really inspiring, and which we have rearranged in our own style." ■

Bhanuj Kappal

